

Scheduled Areas) Act are being implemented, community forest management is being announced, and revenue from timber would go to tribals. At the same time, the gaps in the old schemes are also being addressed.

Q. Are you attempting a transformation from 'Shivraj Mama' to 'Bulldozer Mama'?
A. During my first term as CM, the state was under the terror of dacoit gangs. Back then, I had announced that either Shivraj Singh Chouhan or the dacoits will remain in the state. We didn't publicise our successes then, but MP has been free of the scourge of dacoity for years. SIMI had an organised network, but we have dealt with that too, and Maoism is restricted to only a part of Balaghat district. So, it is not accurate to say I have started using bulldozers now. The previous measures were not discussed earlier. Probably the bulldozing here coincided with the UP election and made people draw a connection. I have always maintained that I will be soft on good people, but tough on those who are evil.

Q. Hindutva emerged as an important political plank in the UP election that the BJP won. Will religious issues dominate the MP election too?
A. Hindutva is never a political issue for us but a question of faith. However, there has been a big change due to the politics of appeasement practised by other parties. Earlier, calling yourself Hindu was considered narrow-minded and communal, but this narrative has changed. The BJP has been clear on this, but now Rahul Gandhi is practising Hindu rituals, Priyanka Gandhi is taking a dip in the Ganga, Akhilesh Yadav is speaking of Krishna Kanhaiya and (Arvind) Kejriwal is taking people on pilgrimages.

Q. You have been planting saplings every day for over a year now. You banned plastics and raised awareness about the environment through the Narmada *parikrama*. However, air and water pollution indices continue to deteriorate...
A. I believe we have to strike a balance between environment and development. I feel doing something in a disciplined way and routinely catches people's attention. I was alone when I started with my 'a sapling a day' pledge last year, but now there is always a group with me. One has to distinguish among offenders against the environment. It seems unfair to book a deprived tribal for taking dry timber from the forest, but there is also the timber mafia that needs to be dealt with effectively.

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Q. The BJP has embarked on Mission 51 at the booth level to enhance its vote share to 51 per cent. The Congress too has a strategy to build the party booth upwards. Will this pose a challenge to you?
A. The Congress is disintegrating and its leadership is in disarray. It does not have the potential to pose a challenge. A real majority is when a party gets more than 51 per cent votes and we are working on it. Prime Minister (Narendra) Modi's policies have drawn everyone to the BJP. Even Christian-majority states, where no one thought the BJP would win, are with the party.

Q. The BJP has been reminding beneficiaries of welfare schemes of what the government has done for them. You announced a waiver of electricity bills, which will result in a loss of Rs 2,250 crore to the exchequer. Is this good politics? Why do governments always reward defaulters and never those who pay their bills?
A. Everyone, including the poor, has a right over the country's resources. But in reality, everyone doesn't have access to these resources, which is what we are trying to correct. If the PM gives a house to the poor, which is his right, and the BJP government tells the beneficiary about it, what is wrong with it? It also creates awareness among people. If it's a good thing to do, people will appreciate it. I feel it is fair to waive the bills for the Covid period as people had lost their livelihoods.

Q. Do you think anti-incumbency will make 2023 your toughest election?
A. Going by the mood in the nation, I think the party will do well in 2023. There is a pro-incumbency feeling due to the work done by the government. ■